

Word family: **second / seconds / secondly / secondary**

Base word: second

Plural: seconds

Adverb: secondly

Related adjective: secondary

Part of speech: ordinal adjective/determiner (序數形容詞 / 限定詞) / noun (名詞) / verb (動詞) / adverbial uses (副詞性用法)

Useful constructions/extensions: second group, second place, second time, second chance, second thought, second nature, second to none, second-hand, second-rate, second opinion, second helping, a second, seconds, second a motion, second someone, secondly

Your passage contains:

> “She definitely belonged to the **second group**.”

Here, **second** means:

the one that comes after the first in an ordered pair or sequence.

Meaning in this passage

The sentence creates two groups:

1. people who pass through your life like background noise;
2. people who leave an echo.

Mrs. Chan belongs to:

> **the second group**

So **second** here means:

the latter of the two groups just mentioned.

Meaning: Number two in an order; the one after the first.

繁體中文： **第二個；後者；在順序上排在第一之後的**

中文翻譯：

> “She definitely belonged to the second group.”

「她明顯屬於**第二類 / 後者那一組**。」

So:

****the second group = 第二組 / 後者****

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. ****second = number two in an order (第二的) — 第二 ; 排第二****

This is the exact core meaning used in your passage.

****Meaning:**** Coming immediately after the first in an ordered sequence.

Practice 1 — Original

> “She belonged to the ****second group****.”

「她屬於****第二組 / 後者****。」

Practice 2

> “Her office is on the ****second floor****.”

「她的辦公室在****二樓****。」

Practice 3

> “This is my ****second attempt****.”

「這是我的****第二次嘗試****。」

****second = 在有順序的事物中排在第一之後****

2. ****the second = the latter of two (後者) — 第二個 ; 後者****

A very useful discourse use and exactly what your passage does.

Practice 4

> “There were two options, and I chose the ****second****.”

「有兩個選項，我選了**第二個 / 後者**。」

Practice 5

> “Of the two explanations, the second is clearer.”

「兩個解釋之中，**後者**比較清楚。」

the second = 在剛提到的兩個人 / 事物中，指後面那個

3. **second time/visit/chance (第二次) — 再一次；第二次**

Practice 6

> “This is the **second time** I’ve met her.”

「這是我**第二次**見她。」

Practice 7

> “He was given a **second chance**.”

「他獲得了**第二次機會 / 重新來過的機會**。」

second + event = 同類事件再次發生，為第二次

4. **second chance (第二次機會) — 重新來過的機會**

A major figurative compound.

Practice 8

> “Everyone deserves a **second chance**.”

「每個人都值得有一次**重新來過的機會**。」

Practice 9

> “The project gave him a second chance to prove himself.”

「這個項目給了他**再次證明自己的機會**。」

****second chance = 第一次失敗 / 錯過後，再獲得一次嘗試機會****

5. ****second = ranking after first (第二名的) — 排第二；次於第一****

A major ranking sense.

Practice 10

> “She finished ****second**** in the race.”

「她在比賽中得****第二名****。」

Practice 11

> “Their team came second.”

「他們的隊伍得了****第二名****。」

****second = 在比賽、排名或評比中排在第一之後****

6. ****second place (第二名) — 亞軍；第二位****

Practice 12

> “He came in ****second place****.”

「他取得****第二名****。」

Practice 13

> “The team finished in second place.”

「球隊最後排名****第二****。」

****second place = 排名緊接第一名的位置****

7. ****second only to (僅次於) — 僅次於.....****

A major fixed expression.

Practice 14

> “Her influence was **second only to** her parents’.”

「她的影響力**僅次於**她父母。」

Practice 15

> “The city is second only to the capital in size.”

「這個城市的規模**僅次於**首都。」

second only to X = 排在 X 之後，但高於其他所有人 / 事物

8. **second to none** (不遜於任何人；首屈一指) — 無與倫比；頂尖

A major idiom.

Practice 16

> “Her patience is **second to none**.”

「她的耐性**無人能及 / 首屈一指**。」

Practice 17

> “Their customer service is second to none.”

「他們的客戶服務**頂尖 / 無與倫比**。」

second to none = 不比任何人差；實際上表示非常優秀、頂尖

It does **not** mean “ranked second.”

9. **second** = another/additional (另一個；再來一個) — 再一個；另一份

A common extension from “number two.”

Practice 18

> “Would you like a **second cup of tea**?”

「你想再喝**第二杯 / 另一杯茶**嗎？」

Practice 19

> “She asked a second question.”

「她又問了**第二個問題**。」

****second = 在第一個之後再增加一個同類事物****

10. ****second helping (第二份食物) — 再添一份****

A common food expression.

Practice 20

> “He had a ****second helping**** of dessert.”

「他又吃了**第二份甜品**。」

Practice 21

> “Would you like a second helping?”

「你想**再添一份**嗎？」

****second helping = 同一道食物再吃一份****

11. ****second = unit of time (秒) — 秒****

A completely separate noun meaning.

****Meaning:**** A unit of time equal to one sixtieth of a minute.

Practice 22

> “Wait a ****second****.”

「等一**秒 / 等一下**。」

Practice 23

> “The race lasted ten seconds.”

「比賽持續了十**秒**。」

second = 時間單位「秒」

This is lexically distinct from ordinal **second = 第二**.

12. **a second = a very short time (一下；片刻) — 一會兒；一下**

A common conversational extension.

Practice 24

> “Give me a **second**.”

「給我**一下 / 等一會兒**。」

Practice 25

> “Can I speak to you for a second?”

「我可以跟你談**一下**嗎？」

a second = 非正式地表示非常短的一段時間，不一定真的是一秒

13. **in a second (馬上；很快) — 一會兒後；很快**

Practice 26

> “I’ll be there **in a second**.”

「我**馬上 / 一會兒就到**。」

Practice 27

> “She’ll call you back in a second.”

「她**很快就會**回電話給你。」

in a second = 在很短時間內

14. ****seconds = very short periods / timing (秒數) — 秒數****

Practice 28

> “Only a few ****seconds**** remained.”

「只剩下幾****秒****。」

Practice 29

> “The difference was less than two seconds.”

「兩者相差不到兩****秒****。」

****seconds = 以秒計算的短時間****

15. ****second = verb: formally support a proposal (附議) — 附議 ; 支持動議****

A genuinely separate formal verb meaning.

****Meaning:**** To formally support a motion or proposal so that it can be discussed or voted on.

Practice 30

> “I ****second the motion****.”

「我****附議這項動議****。」

Practice 31

> “The proposal was seconded by another member.”

「這項提案由另一位成員****附議****。」

****second a motion/proposal = 正式表示支持某項動議，使其可進一步討論 / 表決****

Common in formal meetings.

16. ****I second that (我贊同) — 我同意 ; 我支持****

A common informal extension of the formal meeting sense.

Practice 32

> “‘We should leave early.’ ‘I **second that**.’”

「『我們應該早點走。』 『我**贊成**。』」

Practice 33

> “‘This tea is excellent.’ ‘I second that.’”

「『這茶很好喝。』 『我也**完全同意**。』」

I second that = 非正式表示強烈同意上一個人的說法 / 建議

17. **second = support/assist someone (協助 ; 支援) — 協助 ; 支持**

A less common but established verb use.

Practice 34

> “She was **seconded by** an experienced assistant.”

「她有一位有經驗的助手**協助**。」

Practice 35

> “He seconded the leader during the discussion.”

「他在討論期間**協助 / 支持領導者**。」

second someone = 在工作、任務或競爭中協助 / 支持某人

Lower-frequency than the motion sense.

18. **second = temporarily transfer an employee (借調) — 借調**

A major workplace/administrative use, especially British English.

Practice 36

> “She was **seconded to** another department for six months.”

「她被**借調到**另一個部門六個月。」

Practice 37

> “He was seconded to the overseas office.”

「他被**借調到海外辦事處**。」

second someone to X = 暫時把員工派到另一部門 / 機構工作

This is a genuinely distinct professional use.

19. **secondment (借調) — 借調安排**

A useful family extension.

Practice 38

> “She is on a six-month **secondment**.”

「她正在進行為期六個月的**借調**。」

Practice 39

> “The secondment gave him international experience.”

「這次**借調**給了他國際工作經驗。」

secondment = 員工被暫時調派到另一職位 / 部門 / 組織工作的安排

Especially common in British/international workplace English.

20. **second = assistant in a contest/duel/boxing corner (助手) — 助手 ; 副手**

A separate noun sense.

Practice 40

> “The boxer returned to his **second** between rounds.”

「拳手在回合之間回到自己的**助手 / 場邊指導員**那裡。」

Practice 41

> “His second gave him advice before the next round.”

「他的**助手**在下一回合前給了他建議。」

****a second = 在比賽、拳擊或歷史上的決鬥中協助參與者的人****

Recognition is useful; not a high-priority active meaning.

21. ****second thoughts (重新考慮 ; 改變主意) — 猶豫 ; 再想想****

A major idiom.

Practice 42

> “I’m having ****second thoughts**** about the decision.”

「我對這個決定開始****猶豫 / 重新考慮****。」

Practice 43

> “She accepted the offer without a second thought.”

「她****毫不猶豫地****接受了這個提議。」

****have second thoughts = 第一次決定後重新考慮，開始懷疑原本選擇是否正確****

22. ****without a second thought (毫不猶豫) — 想也不想 ; 毫不遲疑****

Practice 44

> “She helped him ****without a second thought****.”

「她****毫不猶豫地****幫助了他。」

Practice 45

> “He agreed without a second thought.”

「他**想也不想就**同意了。」

without a second thought = 不需要重新考慮，立即行動 / 答應

23. **on second thought / on second thoughts (再想想) — 仔細一想；改變主意**

A major conversational expression.

Practice 46

> “**On second thought**, I'll stay home.”

「**再想想，我還是**留在家吧。」

Practice 47

> “On second thoughts, maybe we should wait.”

「**再仔細想想**，或許我們應該等一下。」

on second thought(s) = 重新考慮後改變 / 修正原本想法

Regional preference varies:

* **on second thought** — especially AmE

* **on second thoughts** — especially BrE

24. **second nature (第二天性；習慣成自然) — 自然而然的習慣**

A major idiom.

Practice 48

> “Speaking in public eventually became **second nature** to her.”

「公開演講最後變成她**自然而然就會做的事**。」

Practice 49

> “After years of practice, checking the details became second nature.”

「多年練習後，檢查細節已經變成**習慣成自然**。」

****second nature = 經長期練習形成、做起來幾乎不用思考的習慣 / 能力****

25. ****second-hand (二手 / 二手的) — 二手 ; 間接取得的****

A major compound with two useful branches.

Practice 50

> “She bought a ****second-hand car****.”

「她買了一輛****二手車****。」

Practice 51

> “I only heard the story ****second-hand****.”

「我只是****間接 / 從別人口中****聽到這件事。」

****second-hand = 曾被其他人擁有過 ; 或資訊不是直接從原始來源取得****

26. ****second-hand goods (二手貨) — 用過再轉售的物品****

Practice 52

> “The shop sells ****second-hand books****.”

「這間店出售****二手書****。」

Practice 53

> “Buying second-hand furniture can save money.”

「買****二手家具****可以省錢。」

****second-hand = 曾由其他人擁有 / 使用過 , 之後再出售或轉讓****

27. ****second-hand information (二手資訊) — 間接資訊****

Practice 54

> “The report is based on **second-hand information**.”

「這份報告基於**第二手 / 間接資訊**。」

Practice 55

> “I prefer direct evidence to second-hand accounts.”

「相比**轉述資料**，我更偏好直接證據。」

second-hand information = 並非直接從事件 / 原始來源得到，而是經其他人轉述

28. **second-rate** (次等的) — 二流；品質較差

A major lexicalized compound.

Practice 56

> “They refused to accept **second-rate work**.”

「他們拒絕接受**二流水準 / 品質差的工作**。」

Practice 57

> “The hotel was expensive but second-rate.”

「酒店很貴，但品質只是**二流**。」

second-rate = 品質較差、低於應有 / 一流水準

Usually negative.

29. **second-class** (次等的 / 二等的) — 二等；次一級

A major compound.

Practice 58

> “They travelled in **second class**.”

「他們乘坐**二等座 / 二等艙**。」

Practice 59

> “Nobody should be treated as a second-class citizen.”

「任何人都不應被當作**次等公民**對待。」

second-class = 等級低於最高級；比喻上亦可指受到較差待遇

30. **second-class citizen (次等公民) — 被當成低一等的人**

Practice 60

> “She refused to be treated like a **second-class citizen**.”

「她拒絕被當成**次等公民 / 低人一等的人**。」

Practice 61

> “The expression describes unequal treatment and status.”

「這個表達指的是**地位和待遇不平等**。」

second-class citizen = 被制度 / 他人當作權利、地位較低的人

31. **second opinion (第二意見；另一位專業人士意見) — 再找一個專業意見**

A major medical/professional expression.

Practice 62

> “She decided to get a **second opinion**.”

「她決定再找一位醫生取得**第二個專業意見**。」

Practice 63

> “You may want a second opinion before making the decision.”

「作決定前，你可能想取得**另一個專業意見**。」

second opinion = 在已有一個專業判斷後，再向另一位專業人士徵詢獨立意見

Especially common medically.

32. **second best (次佳；第二好的) — 第二好；退而求其次**

A common expression.

Practice 64

> “We had to settle for **second best**.”

「我們只好**退而求其次**。」

Practice 65

> “She never wanted to be second best.”

「她從不想只做到**第二好 / 次佳**。」

second best = 比最佳選項稍差的選擇 / 結果

33. **second best = substitute when first choice unavailable (次選) — 次佳選擇**

Practice 66

> “This option is only **second best**.”

「這個選項只是**次佳選擇**。」

Practice 67

> “If the first plan fails, this is the second-best solution.”

「如果第一個計劃失敗，這就是**次佳方案**。」

second best = 第一選擇不可得時採用的次一級方案

34. **secondly (第二；其次) — 第二點；其次**

A major discourse adverb.

Practice 68

> “Firstly, the plan is expensive; **secondly**, it takes too long.”

「第一，計劃很昂貴；**第二 / 其次**，需時太長。」

Practice 69

> “Secondly, we need to consider the cost.”

「**其次**，我們需要考慮成本。」

secondly = 用於列舉論點時介紹第二點

35. **secondary** = less important / coming after primary (次要的) — 次要；第二層次

A major family extension.

Practice 70

> “Cost is a **secondary concern**.”

「成本是**次要考慮因素**。」

Practice 71

> “The main goal is safety; speed is secondary.”

「主要目標是安全，速度只是**次要的**。」

secondary = 重要性低於主要 / 首要事物

36. **secondary** = at the second educational level (中學的) — 中等教育的

This is directly relevant to your passage:

> **secondary school**

Practice 72

> “She was my **secondary school** teacher.”

「她是我的**中學老師**。」

Practice 73

> “He teaches at a secondary school.”

「他在**中學**任教。」

secondary education/school = 小學之後、高等教育之前的中等教育階段

This is a lexicalized educational use of **secondary**.

Important distinction: **second vs two**

two

= cardinal number; quantity.

> two groups

= 兩組.

second

= ordinal number; position/order.

> the second group

= 第二組.

So:

two = how many

second = which position

Important distinction: **second vs another**

second

= specifically another one after the first.

another

= one more/additional, without always emphasizing exact ordinal position.

> “a second cup”

≈ another cup after the first.

But **second** explicitly links it to the first.

Important distinction: **second vs latter**

In your passage:

> **the second group**

and:

> **the latter group**

can both mean:

> 後者.

second

focuses on numerical/order position.

latter

specifically identifies the second of two previously mentioned items.

Important distinction: **second vs next**

second

= number two from a fixed starting point.

next

= the one immediately after the current one.

If you are already on item 4:

> the next item = item 5

not:

> the second item.

Important distinction: ****second vs secondary****

****second****

= ordinal position number two.

****secondary****

often means:

* less important;

* at a second educational/structural level.

Compare:

> second reason

= 第二個原因.

> secondary reason

= 次要原因.

Very different.

Important distinction: ****second reason vs secondary reason****

This is crucial.

****second reason****

= the reason listed after the first.

It may still be very important.

secondary reason

= less important than the main reason.

Order ≠ importance.

Important distinction: **second place vs second best**

second place

= actual ranking number two.

second best

= next-best quality/option after the best.

A person can finish second in a race without being objectively “second best” overall.

Important distinction: **second to none vs second place**

These almost look contradictory.

second place

= rank number two.

second to none

= inferior to nobody → effectively top-class.

So:

> second to none

means:

> excellent / unbeatable,

not “second.”

Important distinction: **second = ordinal vs second = time**

Compare:

> “the **second** group”

= 第二組

versus:

> “wait a **second**”

= 等一秒 / 一下.

Same spelling and pronunciation, unrelated lexical meanings in modern learner use.

Important distinction: **a second vs one second**

one second

= exactly the time unit in literal measurement.

a second

in conversation often means:

> a very short moment.

> “Give me a second.”

does not promise exactly 1.000 seconds.

Important distinction: **second a motion vs support an idea**

second a motion

= formally support a proposal in a meeting procedure.

support an idea

= generally agree with/back it.

****Second**** is more procedural/formal.

Important distinction: **I second that vs I agree**

**I agree**

= general agreement.

**I second that**

= stronger conversational echo of formal “second a motion”; means “I support exactly what was just said.”

Both are natural, but ****I second that**** is more idiomatic/playful.

Important distinction: **secondment vs transfer**

**secondment**

= temporary assignment to another role/department/organization.

**transfer**

= may be permanent.

So:

> seconded for six months

strongly suggests temporary placement.

Important distinction: **second-hand = used vs second-hand = indirect**

Compare:

> “second-hand furniture”

= 二手家具

versus:

> “second-hand information”

= 間接 / 轉述資訊

Same compound, different branches.

Important distinction: ****second-hand vs old****

****second-hand****

= previously owned/used.

****old****

= not new in age.

A nearly new phone can still be:

> second-hand.

And an old object can still belong to its original owner.

Important distinction: ****second-hand vs second-rate****

****second-hand****

= previously used / indirectly obtained.

****second-rate****

= poor quality / below first-class.

A second-hand item can be excellent quality.

Do not confuse them.

Important distinction: ****second thoughts vs think twice****

These overlap.

have second thoughts

= start reconsidering a previous decision.

think twice

= carefully reconsider before acting.

> “I’m having second thoughts about going.”

decision already leaning/possibly made.

> “Think twice before going.”

warning before action.

Important distinction: **second nature vs natural ability**

second nature

= learned behaviour that has become automatic through repetition.

natural ability

= ability that seems innate.

Something can become second nature even if it was difficult at first.

Important distinction: **second opinion vs another opinion**

another opinion

= any additional viewpoint.

second opinion

= specifically an independent professional assessment after an initial one.

Especially important in healthcare.

Important distinction: **second-class vs second-rate**

second-class

= officially/informally lower category/status.

second-rate

= poor/inferior quality.

A second-class train ticket is not necessarily “bad quality”; it is a service category.

Family-extension sweep

The practical **second** family is unusually rich because one spelling covers ordinal, temporal, verbal, professional, and idiomatic meanings:

- * **second — ordinal** = 第二
- * **the second — latter** = 後者
- * **second time/chance** = 第二次 / 重新機會
- * **second place** = 第二名
- * **second only to** = 僅次於
- * **second to none** = 無與倫比 / 首屈一指
- * **second cup/helping** = 再一杯 / 再一份
- * **a second — time unit** = 一秒
- * **a second — short moment** = 一下 / 片刻
- * **in a second** = 馬上 / 很快
- * **second a motion** = 附議
- * **I second that** = 我贊同
- * **second someone** = 協助 / 支持某人
- * **second someone to another department** = 借調
- * **secondment** = 借調
- * **a second — assistant** = 助手 / 副手
- * **second thoughts** = 重新考慮 / 猶豫
- * **on second thought(s)** = 再想想
- * **without a second thought** = 毫不猶豫
- * **second nature** = 習慣成自然
- * **second-hand goods** = 二手物品
- * **second-hand information** = 二手 / 間接資訊
- * **second-rate** = 二流 / 次等
- * **second-class** = 二等 / 次一級

* **second opinion** = 第二專業意見
 * **second best** = 次佳 / 退而求其次
 * **secondly** = 其次 / 第二點
 * **secondary — importance** = 次要的
 * **secondary school** = 中學 / 中等教育

The main semantic branches are:

- > **ordinal position: number two**
- > **additional occurrence after the first**
- > **time unit: one second**
- > **formal support / assistance**
- > **temporary workplace assignment**

plus a large set of lexicalized expressions:

> **second thoughts / second nature / second-hand / second-rate / second opinion**

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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second — ordinal	在有順序的事物中排在第一之後；第二
the second — latter	在剛提到的兩個人 / 事物中指後面那一個
second time/chance	第一次之後再次發生 / 再獲一次機會
second place	排名緊接第一名的位置
second only to	只排在指定對象之後，而高於其他所有對象
second to none	不遜於任何人 / 事物；非常出色、頂尖
second — additional	第一個之後再增加一個同類事物
second — time	等於六十分之一分鐘的時間單位
a second — moment	非正式指非常短的一段時間
second a motion	正式支持 / 附議某項動議，使其可繼續處理
I second that	非正式表示自己完全贊同剛才的說法
second — assist	在任務 / 競爭中協助、支援某人
second — workplace	暫時把員工派往另一部門 / 機構工作；借調
secondment	暫時調派到另一崗位 / 部門 / 組織的工作安排
a second — assistant	在拳擊、競賽等場合協助參與者的人
second thoughts	第一次決定後重新考慮並開始懷疑原本選擇
on second thought(s)	重新考慮後修正 / 改變原來想法
without a second thought	不需要重新考慮，毫不猶豫地

second nature	經長期練習形成、做起來幾乎不用思考的習慣 / 能力	
second-hand — goods	曾由其他人擁有 / 使用過的二手物品	
second-hand — information	並非直接從原始來源取得，而經他人轉述的資訊	
second-rate	品質低於一流水準、較差的	
second-class	等級 / 地位低於最高一級的	
second opinion	已有一個專業判斷後，再取得的獨立專業意見	
second best	最佳選項之後的次佳選擇	
secondly	在列舉論點時引入第二點；其次	
secondary — importance	重要性低於主要 / 首要事物的	
secondary school	小學之後、高等教育之前的中等教育階段	

For your original passage

> “Some people pass through your life like background noise, while others leave an echo, and she definitely belonged to the **second group**.”

The sentence establishes exactly two categories:

First group

> people who pass through your life without leaving much lasting impact

Second group

> people who leave an echo — their influence remains

Mrs. Chan belongs to:

> **the second group**

Therefore:

second = the latter of the two groups previously mentioned

and the natural Chinese is:

> **第二組 / 後者**

This is a particularly nice example of **second** functioning as more than a bare number.

It provides **discourse reference**:

> first category

> → second category

> → “she belongs to the second.”

The most important learner contrasts are:

> **the second group**

> = 第二組 / 後者

> **the second time**

> = 第二次

> **a second chance**

> = 重新來過的機會

> **come second**

> = 得第二名

> **second only to**

> = 僅次於

> **second to none**

> = 無與倫比

> **wait a second**

> = 等一下

> **I second the motion**

> = 我附議這項動議

> **I second that**

> = 我贊同

> **be seconded to another department**

> = 被借調到另一部門

> **have second thoughts**

> = 開始重新考慮 / 猶豫

> **on second thoughts**

> = 再想想

> **without a second thought**

> = 毫不猶豫

> **second nature**

> = 習慣成自然

> ****second-hand car****

> = 二手車

> ****second-hand information****

> = 第二手 / 間接資訊

> ****second-rate work****

> = 二流水準的工作

> ****second opinion****

> = 第二個專業意見

> ****secondary reason****

> = 次要原因

> ****secondary school****

> = 中學

So ****second**** is much richer than simply:

> ****second = 第二****

and in your original passage it specifically means:

****“the latter of the two groups just described — the people whose presence leaves a lasting echo in your life.”****